



Hilltop fortress

This aerial view of a strategic hamlet shows four lines of defense. These usually consisted of trenches strewn with traps and mines and mounted by barbed wire. Some hamlets also had a watchtower.

Viet Cong response

For their part, though initially alarmed by the program, the Viet Cong soon became fully aware of its shortcomings. Their response was to launch a systematic campaign that targeted the most important hamlets. Specially trained Viet Cong units were organized to destroy them, either by direct attack or infiltration.

At Hoa Phu, in the Long An province in the Mekong Delta, an area particularly resistant to the program, villagers urged on by Viet Cong guerrillas who had infiltrated the settlement, tore down its defenses and returned to their native villages. In total, 200 of the strategic hamlets in the province were similarly destroyed or simply abandoned.